
HOUND'S HEARTH

The Honest Dog Nutrition Guide

What's actually worth buying, how much your dog needs,
and how to avoid overpaying.

A free guide from your advice-first dog-care partner

Honest guidance, not hype

Hound's Hearth exists to help dog lovers and breeders make better choices — without the marketing noise. This short guide covers the essentials every dog parent should know: how to read a food label, how much to actually feed, when a supplement earns its place (and when to skip it), and a simple grooming routine. No jargon. No hard sell. Just honest answers you can act on today.

PART 1

How to read a dog-food label

The label tells you almost everything — if you know where to look. Here's how to judge any bag in 30 seconds.

Start with the first five ingredients

Ingredients are listed by weight, so the first few make up most of the recipe. You want a **named animal protein** first — "deboned chicken," "salmon," or "lamb" — not a vague "meat meal" or a grain.

Green flags

- A specific, named meat in position one
- Whole foods you recognize: sweet potato, oats, carrots, blueberries
- A named fat source ("chicken fat")
- An AAFCO "complete and balanced" statement

Red & yellow flags

- Corn, wheat or soy high on the list
- Vague terms: "meat by-product," "animal digest," "added color"
- Long chemical preservatives (BHA, BHT, ethoxyquin)

Watch the splitting trick: a brand may list "corn," "corn gluten" and "ground corn" separately so no single one tops the list. Add them back together in your head.

Marketing words that mean nothing

"Premium," "holistic" and "gourmet" have no legal definition on pet food. Judge the ingredient panel, not the front of the bag. And "grain-free" isn't automatically better — it swaps grains for peas, lentils or potato. Most dogs do well on a quality recipe with wholesome grains like oats or brown rice.

PART 2

How much should I feed my dog?

Bag guidelines are a starting point, not gospel. Here's the simple math vets use.

The vet formula, in plain English

Start with the **Resting Energy Requirement (RER)**: $RER = 70 \times (\text{body weight in kg})^{0.75}$. Then multiply by a factor for life stage and activity to get daily calories (MER).

Situation	× RER
Weight loss	1.0
Senior / low activity	1.4
Neutered adult (normal)	1.6
Active adult	2.0
Puppy (4–12 mo)	2.0
Puppy (under 4 mo)	3.0

Cups vs. calories

"2 cups a day" means nothing without the food's energy density. Divide daily calories by the kcal-per-cup on your bag. Skip the arithmetic — the **Dog Planner at houndshearth.com/planner** does it for you and converts to cups per day, bags per month and cost.

Switching foods: the 7-day transition

- Days 1–2: 25% new, 75% old
- Days 3–4: 50/50
- Days 5–6: 75% new, 25% old
- Day 7+: 100% new

Adding a probiotic during the switch makes the transition smoother for sensitive dogs.

Body-condition check beats any chart

Feel your dog's ribs — you should feel them under a thin layer, like the back of your hand. Can't feel ribs? Trim ~10%. Too visible? Add ~10%. Recheck every two weeks.

Do dogs really need supplements?

Most healthy dogs on a complete diet don't need a cabinet full of pills. But a few targeted supplements genuinely earn their place.

The honest rule

A "complete and balanced" food already covers baseline vitamins and minerals. Supplements are about **targeting a specific issue** — not topping up a good diet. No issue to target? Save your money.

The ones that tend to be worth it

- **Omega-3 oil** — the most universally useful. A dull coat or itchy skin often improves within weeks.
- **Probiotics** — for loose stools, gas or a sensitive gut.
- **Joint support** (glucosamine + chondroitin) — for large breeds and seniors; start before stiffness sets in.
- **Dental support** — a daily topper reduces tartar and breath odor for dogs who won't tolerate brushing.

Introduce one supplement at a time and give it 3–4 weeks. If you can't tell whether it's helping, it probably isn't the right one.

When to skip — or ask your vet first

- Stacking products that duplicate the same nutrients
- Adding supplements your dog shows no need for
- Any supplement for a pregnant dog, a dog on medication, or with a health condition — check with your vet

At-home grooming basics

You don't need a salon to keep your dog fresh, healthy and comfortable. Here's a simple routine, tuned to your dog's coat.

How often should you bathe a dog?

For most dogs, **every 4–6 weeks** is plenty — over-bathing strips natural oils. Between baths, cleansing wipes or a deodorizing mist handle muddy paws.

A simple weekly routine

- **Brush** 2–3×/week (daily for double coats)
- **Ears** — check weekly; clean if waxy or smelly (never poke deep)
- **Skin** — scan for hot spots; soothe early irritation
- **Nails** — trim every 3–4 weeks; clicking on the floor means too long

By coat type

Coat type	What it needs
Double (Husky, Golden, Lab)	Frequent brushing; never shave; de-shed seasonally
Curly (Poodle, Doodle)	Brush to the skin to prevent mats; regular trims
Short (Lab, Beagle)	Weekly brush; easy baths; watch for dry skin
Wiry (Terriers, Schnauzer)	Brushing plus periodic hand-stripping
Long/silky (Yorkie, Shih Tzu)	Daily brushing; tear-stain care

Make it a spa day, not a wrestling match: go slow, reward with a treat after each step, and keep early sessions short.

The honest bottom line

Look for a named meat first and whole-food ingredients. Feed to your dog's body condition, not just the bag. Use supplements to target a real need — coat, gut, joints, dental — not to pad out a good diet. And when in doubt, your veterinarian comes first.

How Hound's Hearth helps

We curate a small, trusted lineup, build you a tailored feeding plan with our Dog Planner, and our advisor Scout can answer questions any time. Honest advice first, products second — always.

This guide is general education, not veterinary advice. Always consult a licensed veterinarian about your dog's individual health and diet. Products featured by Hound's Hearth are fulfilled by our supply partner; we may earn a commission at no extra cost to you.